Within a few days, the pain arrived. My old knee injury, one that hours of physiotherapy had banished, was back. The next morning I found myself in tears, sitting alone in a metal container. How was I ever going to walk the 3,800 kilometres that lay ahead? The crutch of arrogance was gone.

We would start walking in the darkness before dawn. Almost immediately, the pain would begin. Like a hungry wolf, it would follow me everywhere I went, waiting for me to stop. A few days into the walk, my physiotherapist joined us. He came and gave me sage advice. The pain remained.

And then I started to notice something. Every time I would think about stopping, every time I considered giving up, someone would come and gift me the energy to continue. Once it was a lovely little girl with a beautiful letter, another time an old lady with some banana chips, then a man who suddenly ran up and hugged me. It was as if a silent energy kept helping me, and like fireflies in a dark forest, it was everywhere. When I really needed it, it was there to help and guide me. The Yatra progressed. At first, I wanted to tell everyone what I thought. I wanted to show them what I understood. I spoke about solutions to their problems. But soon the number of people became so large and the pain so persistent that I started to observe and listen.

There was always a din in the space where we walked, with loud slogans, clicking cameras, and people pushing and shoving. Again and again and again. Every day, for eight to ten hours, I would just listen, and try and ignore my knee.

Then one day, I felt a silence I had never felt before. I could hear nothing but the voice of the person holding my hand and talking to me. The inner voice that had spoken to me ever since I was a little child was gone. It felt as if something had died. He was a farmer, and he spoke about his crop. He was crying as he showed me the strands of rotten cotton. I saw the years of suffering in his hands. In those puffs of cotton, I could see the fear he felt for his children. On his sunken face, I could see the nights he had spent hungry. He spoke about how he had helplessly watched his father die. He